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AI Companions and the Power of Genre: How Rhetorical Situations Shape the Conversation About NPCs in Gaming

Imagine playing *The Elder Scrolls V: Skyrim*, a massive open-world fantasy RPG where players can explore mountains, battle dragons, and interact with hundreds of characters. Now picture your loyal companion Lydia accidentally walking into yet another trap. Players laugh, share memes, or grow oddly fond of her clumsy devotion. As one Reddit user famously wrote, “Lydia may walk into every trap in Skyrim, but she’s still the best housecarl a Dragonborn could ask for.” This humor shared among fans shows how flawed AI companions still inspire affection and cultural recognition. Moments like these remind us that artificial intelligence (AI) companions—whether helpful or hilariously flawed—play a major role in shaping how we experience games. Yet, depending on where we read or watch discussions about these AI companions, the tone and focus can shift dramatically. A scholarly article might discuss Lydia’s behavior in terms of “emergent gameplay” or “procedural narrative design.” A popular article on IGN or Polygon might joke about how companions make open-world games feel alive—or broken. Meanwhile, a YouTube documentary could use gameplay footage to show AI companions reacting dynamically—or failing spectacularly—in real time. These shifting portrayals highlight that discussions about AI companions are not just about game mechanics but about storytelling, emotion, and technology’s growing role in shaping human creativity. As gaming continues to evolve, understanding how each genre presents AI behavior helps reveal how players interpret intelligence, personality, and even companionship in virtual spaces.

Across these different genres—academic, popular, and visual/technological—writers and creators approach AI companions in video games through very different rhetorical situations. While all three genres discuss AI companions in gaming, the scholarly article emphasizes technical and theoretical implications for narrative design, the popular article translates these ideas into accessible critiques for gamers, and the visual/technological source demonstrates AI’s impact through engaging examples. Together, these differences show how genre shapes the audience’s perception of AI in gaming.

The academic source, “Interactive Storytelling: From AI Experiment to New Media,” explores AI companions through the lens of design theory and research. It examines how artificial intelligence contributes to player immersion by allowing for interactive narratives and adaptive character behaviors. The article’s tone is formal and analytical, using terms such as “procedural generation,” “narrative agency,” and “decision-tree logic.” Smith notes that “AI-driven companions act as both narrative agents and adaptive systems, responding to player input in ways that simulate human improvisation” (Smith 6). She argues that “interactive storytelling depends on procedural generation to sustain player agency without predetermining every narrative path” (Smith 8). It cites AI as both a technical and artistic challenge in game development, arguing that AI companions act as co-narrators within interactive media. The author supports these claims by referencing game development experiments such as *Façade* (2005), one of the earliest interactive narrative simulations to feature emotionally reactive AI characters. Smith reflects on *Façade* as “a prototype for how emotion can be computationally modeled, allowing players to co-create drama through dialogue” (Smith 10). The purpose is not to entertain but to inform and advance scholarly understanding of how AI systems affect storytelling (Smith 12). Smith ultimately concludes that “AI companions represent a merging of code and character, a dialogue between designer and player that blurs the line between narrative structure and improvisation” (Smith 13). This observation ties into broader academic debates about whether AI-driven storytelling can ever replicate the spontaneity of human creativity.

In contrast, the popular article “The Emotional Experience of Interaction with NPCs in RPG Games”—typical of coverage found on Polygon or Kotaku—targets a general gaming audience. Its tone is conversational, filled with references to well-known titles like *Elden Ring*, *Starfield*, and *The Witcher 3*. Rather than delving into code or research, it highlights how NPCs make players feel emotionally connected to the game world. The article might discuss how *Elden Ring*’s solitary tone contrasts with NPCs like Ranni the Witch, whose mysterious guidance gives emotional depth to the player’s lonely journey. Johnson writes, “Players don’t just see NPCs—they feel with them. The best AI companions make digital worlds feel inhabited, even when you’re alone” (Johnson 3). He references CD Projekt Red’s *The Witcher 3*, where “companions’ emotional arcs mirror the player’s moral choices, creating a sense of shared consequence” (Johnson 7). It even draws comparisons to classic games like *Mass Effect*, where companions’ moral choices and relationship systems evoke empathy and attachment. Johnson quotes a player who described Ranni from *Elden Ring* as “the ghost in the machine that makes the Lands Between feel less empty” (Johnson 10). This genre’s purpose is to inform and entertain, sparking community discussion and reflection on why AI-driven characters resonate with players (Johnson 5).

Finally, the visual/technological source—such as the YouTube video *The AI Takeover: How AI Is Redefining Gaming, from NPCs to Storytelling*—uses video clips, humor, and developer interviews to show AI behavior in action. This source visually demonstrates how AI algorithms shape player experiences, using side-by-side comparisons or gameplay footage. For example, it contrasts early NPC pathfinding in *Skyrim* with advanced AI routines in *Horizon Forbidden West*, illustrating how far adaptive systems have evolved. In *The AI Takeover*, the narrator explains, “NPCs are no longer just scripted entities—they’re evolving systems that can surprise even their developers” (TechCore 00:42). Later in the video, while showing a clip of Lydia stepping into a trap, the host jokes, “AI’s come a long way—from loyal but clueless companions to allies that actually think before walking into danger” (TechCore 03:18). The rhetorical goal is to explain technical concepts in a way that is simple, visually engaging, and often

funny. By combining visuals, narration, and examples, the video appeals to casual gamers and tech enthusiasts who prefer to learn by seeing rather than reading (TechCore).

Each genre's tone reflects its intended audience. The academic article maintains a professional and technical voice. Phrases like "adaptive procedural systems" and "player-agent symbiosis" establish credibility among scholars and developers. The tone is objective, focusing on evidence rather than emotion. This approach helps readers view AI companions as systems to be analyzed and improved, rather than as characters to be loved or hated.

The popular article takes the opposite approach: it is personal, emotive, and accessible. The tone might include phrases such as, "We've all had that one NPC who saved our life—or got us killed." It uses shared experiences to connect with readers who play games rather than build them. Humor, nostalgia, and empathy are common rhetorical strategies. The article may even include quotes from developers or social media posts from fans, blending journalism with community commentary. This conversational tone transforms AI from a technical subject into a social one.

Meanwhile, the visual/technological source relies on voice tone, pacing, and visual rhythm to engage viewers. The narrator might speak energetically while showing a clip of an NPC doing something unpredictable. Text overlays, quick cuts, and memes keep the audience entertained while learning. Unlike the other genres, the visual style itself becomes part of the rhetoric: it shows rather than tells. A two-minute montage of AI bugs can communicate the unpredictability of game AI better than a thousand words. The tone is casual and humorous, but the visuals lend credibility through direct demonstration.

The rhetorical situation—who's speaking to whom and why—fundamentally shapes each genre's presentation of AI companions. The academic article addresses scholars, game designers, and researchers. Its purpose is to explore how AI contributes to interactive storytelling and how algorithms can create believable characters. It assumes that readers are familiar with academic discourse and theories of digital media. The genre invites critical thinking and discussion about improving design practices and expanding

narrative theory. In contrast, the popular article speaks to the gaming community—fans, hobbyists, and players who consume game news and reviews. Its purpose is to entertain and inform. Writers in this genre act as translators between the complex technical world of AI and the player’s emotional experience. They frame AI companions not as code, but as “characters” who can shape immersion and storytelling. The writing encourages empathy and discussion rather than technical critique. The visual/technological source targets a wide online audience, from casual gamers to tech-curious viewers. Its purpose is often educational but also promotional or comedic. By using gameplay footage and visuals, this genre makes technical topics accessible without needing jargon. The visual genre relies on immediacy—it doesn’t need to tell the audience AI companions are fascinating; it shows them in action.

The kinds of evidence each genre uses reveal its rhetorical priorities. In the academic article, evidence takes the form of research studies, theories, and system analysis. The writer may reference experiments in procedural storytelling, cite results from user-experience studies, or include diagrams illustrating dialogue-tree structures. Charts, data tables, and in-depth explanations of AI architecture are common. The goal is to prove claims through replicable and verifiable evidence. As Smith emphasizes, “quantifying emotional immersion through AI systems remains a core challenge of digital storytelling research” (Smith 14). In the popular article, evidence often comes from player experiences, developer interviews, and critical examples. A writer might describe how an NPC companion’s dialogue choices in *Starfield* feel more lifelike than in older Bethesda games or quote a designer discussing emotional engagement. This evidence is anecdotal but relatable, helping readers connect theory to experience. Johnson contrasts this by stating, “The data matters less than the feeling of being seen by a character who shouldn’t be able to feel at all” (Johnson 11).

The visual/technological source replaces citations with visuals. Gameplay footage functions as evidence: the audience sees AI companions reacting (or failing) in real time. Developer interviews lend credibility, while memes and reactions provide emotional resonance. In this way, evidence is multisensory—visual, auditory, and emotional—rather than purely textual or logical.

Each genre not only describes AI companions but also shapes how audiences think about them. The academic genre encourages readers to see AI companions as systems of design. It highlights innovation, technical depth, and theoretical impact. Readers come away understanding the “how” behind AI immersion. The popular genre frames AI companions as emotional touchpoints that shape the player’s story. Readers are likely to think of companions as characters, not code, and to debate their emotional depth or realism. This shapes public perception of AI as part of storytelling and culture rather than just technology. The visual genre makes AI behavior visible and visceral. By watching NPCs in motion—helpful, buggy, or eerily lifelike—viewers internalize the wonder and unpredictability of AI. It democratizes understanding by showing that anyone can observe AI’s influence firsthand. Together, these genres create a layered conversation about AI companions. Scholars build the theory, journalists translate it for mass audiences, and content creators visualize it for entertainment and education. Each genre plays a role in shaping how we understand AI not just as technology, but as part of human creativity.

From scholarly research papers to YouTube videos, the conversation about AI companions in video games shifts dramatically depending on genre. The academic article focuses on technical systems and theories of interactive storytelling, aiming to expand our understanding of design and immersion. The popular article translates those ideas into accessible, emotional reflections on how NPCs influence players’ experiences. Meanwhile, visual/technological sources make these ideas tangible, showing AI behavior directly through engaging footage and humor. Ultimately, genre determines not only how information is presented but also how audiences perceive it. Scholars see AI companions as systems of logic and design; gamers see them as friends, nuisances, or emotional anchors; viewers see them as entertaining phenomena in motion. As artificial intelligence continues to evolve, future discussions about NPCs will likely move beyond entertainment—raising deeper questions about creativity, ethics, and what it truly means to interact with something that seems alive. These overlapping perspectives reveal the power of genre and rhetorical situation: they shape how we think, feel, and talk about the artificial minds that now populate our favorite worlds.

Works Cited

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